had a Native American grandmother or an African father didn't, of course, reveal anything about their intelligence, kindness or honesty. These bogus categories didn't discover or describe any truth about humans; they imposed an oppressive, mythological order on them.

As computers replace humans in more and more bureaucracies, from tax collection and health care to security and justice, they too may create a mythology and impose it on us with unprecedented efficiency. In a world ruled by paper documents, bureaucrats had difficulty policing racial borderlines or tracking everyone's exact ancestry. People could get false documents. A *zambo* could move to another town and pretend to be a *pardo*. A Black person could sometimes pass as white. Similarly in the Soviet Union, kulak children occasionally managed to falsify their papers to get a good job or a place in college. In Nazi Europe, Jews could sometimes adopt an Aryan identity. But it would be much harder to game the system in a world ruled by computers that can read irises and DNA rather than paper documents. Computers could be frighteningly efficient in imposing false labels on people and making sure that the labels stick.

For example, social credit systems could create a new underclass of 'low-credit people'. Such a system may claim to merely 'discover' the truth through an empirical and mathematical process of aggregating points to form an overall score. But how exactly would it define pro-social and antisocial behaviours? What happens if such a system deducts points for criticising government policies, for reading foreign literature, for practising a minority religion, for having no religion or for socialising with other low-credit people? As a thought experiment, consider what might happen when the new technology of the social credit system meets traditional religions.

Religions like Judaism, Christianity and Islam have always imagined that somewhere above the clouds there is an all-seeing eye that gives or deducts points for everything we do and that our eternal fate depends on the score we accumulate. Of course, nobody could be certain of their score. You could know for sure only after you died. In practical terms, this meant that sinfulness and sainthood were intersubjective phenomena whose very definition depended on public opinion. What might happen if the Iranian regime, for example, decides to use its computer-based surveillance system not only to enforce its strict hijab laws, but to turn sinfulness and sainthood into precise inter-computer phenomena? You didn't wear a hijab on the street – that's −10 points. You ate on Ramadan before sunset – another 20